Kolkata and who were still on board. I waited patiently as the crew changed. Once the new crew had taken up their positions, I asked them to screen off one side so that the incoming passengers wouldn't start taking pictures, which might end up delaying the flight. I was happy to sign autographs once we were airborne rather than inconveniencing other passengers and delaying the journey. The crew agreed and I settled down in my seat.

Soon after take-off it hit me that I was travelling to play the last Test match of my career. It had all come to an end very quickly. In no time I would have a microphone in my hand and would be expected to speak to the world, to say something to all my fans and supporters about what I was feeling. It would also be my last opportunity to thank the people who had stood by me over the years. And yet I had not planned what I would say or exactly who I needed to thank. I knew I had to be careful, because on a previous occasion I had had to make a similar speech and thought I had thanked everybody – until the commentator Harsha Bhogle came to the rescue and whispered in my ear that I hadn't mentioned Anjali! Sitting on that plane from Kolkata, I realized that I had two hours when no one would call me or speak to me and it was the ideal time to think about my speech. I took out my iPad and started to make a note of all the people I needed to thank, going right back to the very beginning.

While I was doing so, I had to keep reminding myself that I still had ten days left in my career and that I was going to enjoy every moment on the field. I had two innings left and wanted to leave my fans with memories they would cherish. As the flight started its descent into Mumbai, I thought back to the years gone by. It had been quite a journey.